During my time at Iowa State University, I have taken several general education courses. These courses serve to complete my education as a well-rounded student by allowing me to see problem-solving from a different perspective. A key aspect of being a good engineer is a well-rounded understanding of current issues, along with a broad, developed perspective on those issues, past and present. General education courses have allowed me to develop these perspectives on current and past issues.

History is an incredibly important subject for problem solving. Studying history allows someone to learn from the past mistakes and successes. That is why I am glad I took Architecture 3210: History of the American City. I originally took this course expecting to only learn about examples of different architectural styles in America, but the class taught me so much more. In order to fully understand the history of the American city, a complete understanding of political, economic, and societal issues is required. Understanding why building codes were developed and what the original tenements in America were like gave me context on the modern-day housing crisis. I also got to see just how redlining and other discriminatory practices created huge class and income disparities between different ethnic groups in America. This knowledge relates to the modern housing crisis, as zoning laws are a current ethical debate that drives costs higher.

Another course I took during my years at Iowa State University was ECON 101. This course teaches you the basics of economics, which has directly helped me every step of my engineering career. The economy directly influences what gets engineered and how effective the engineering solutions will be. Topics like supply and demand, cartels and game theory, and competitive markets all apply to engineering and, more broadly, problem-solving as a whole. If I wanted to design a new device, my knowledge of economics would help me to understand how much the watch should cost and when I should stop manufacturing it.

General education courses may not seem important at a first glance since they don't explicitly relate to engineering. But through my time at Iowa State University, I have come to understand that the breadth of knowledge gained through these courses is what gives a great engineer the context and perspective to develop new solutions to modern problems. Classes such as history and economics are classes that gave me that needed context and perspective and will serve me well in my future career.